DONNERSTAG

■ 30 YEARS OF FREITAG

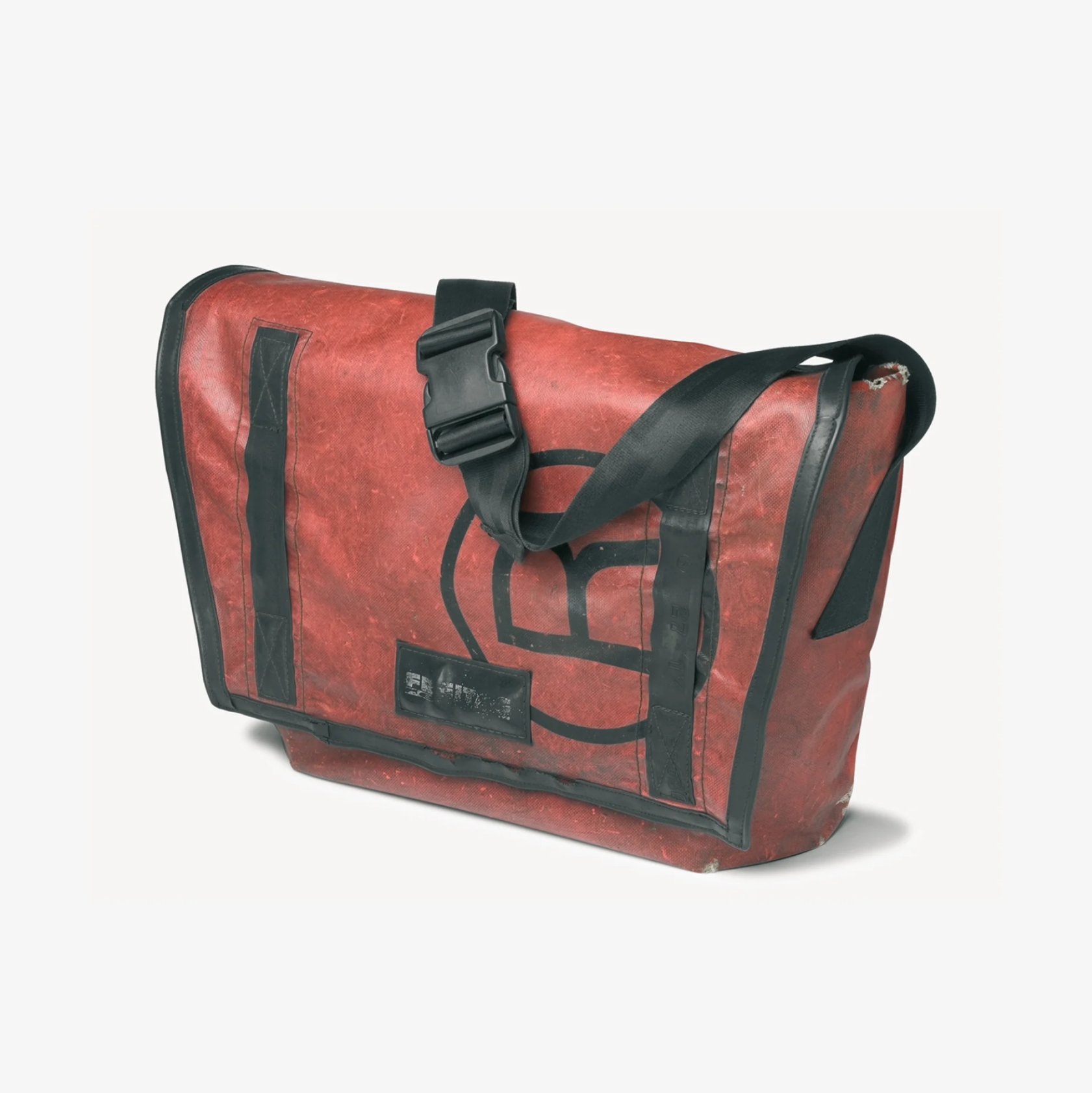
The original copy of the copy of the original

Something that started in the fall of 1993 as the idea of two brothers in a shared apartment in Zurich has developed into a company that brings unique recycled bags to the streets, from Europe to Asia. Then, as now, we've been driven by the notion of keeping used materials in circulation for as long as possible. And, in the future, even closing the cycles. On our 30th anniversary, we reflect on our beginnings and, as a tribute, copy the counterfeit that made the FREITAG bag an original.

■ THE FIRST BAG

For three decades, our bags have stood not only for design and functionality but also for the resource-saving use of materials and durability. The first F13 TOP CAT Messenger Bag, which was admitted to the the Museum of Modern Art in New York (MoMA) design collection in 2003, has given rise to an extensive range of bags and accessories.

For some models today, we combine used truck tarp with recycled PET textile or B-stock airbags, and we even offer a circular smartphone protective sleeve made of worn-out ski boots. Always true to our corporate philosophy: «We think and act in cycles».



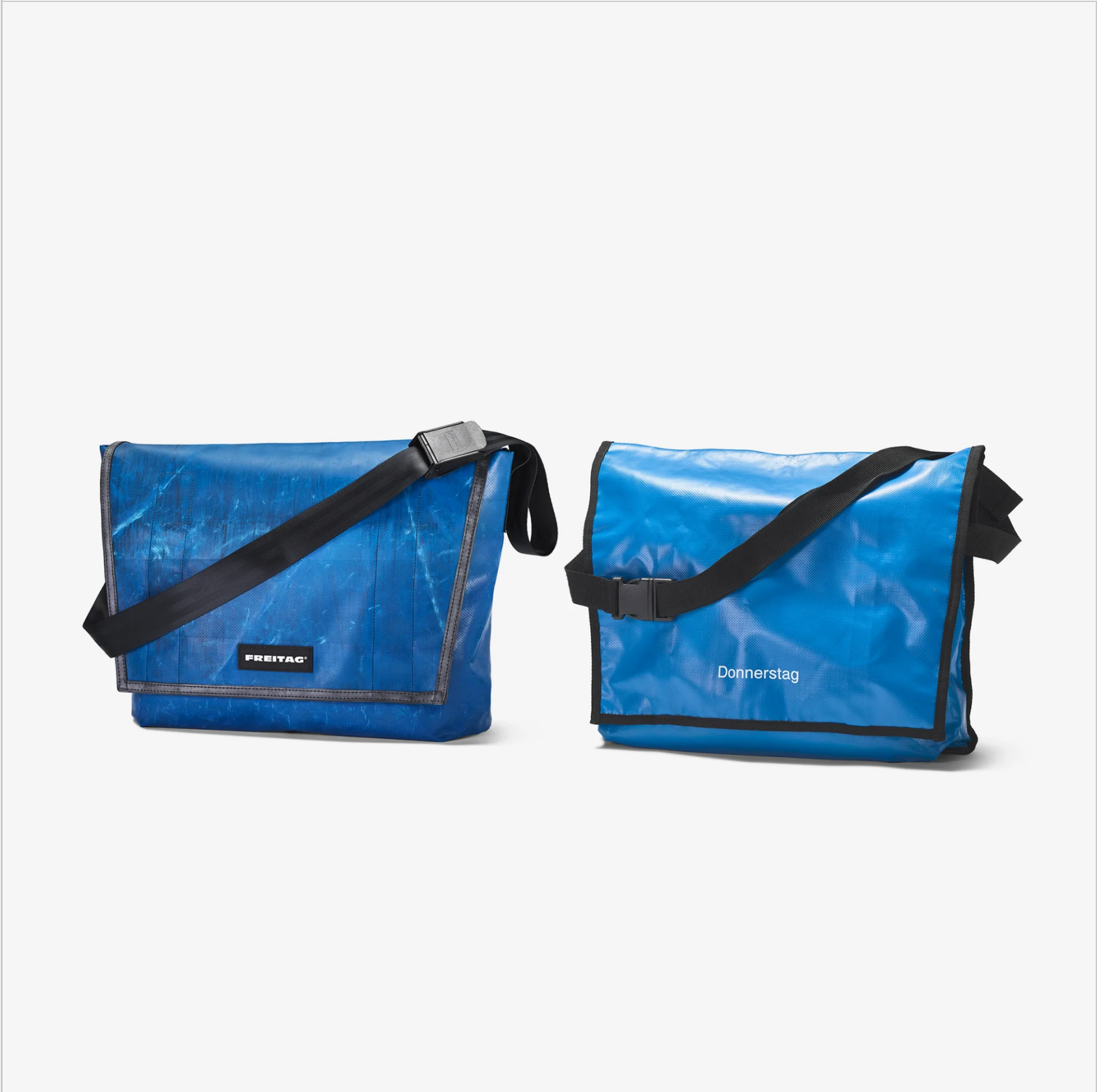
■ SUDDENLY, THE BAG WAS IN A SUPERMARKET

Let's jump back to year three of our story. In 1997, Markus Freitag went shopping at a branch of one of Switzerland's largest supermarket chains. Suddenly, somewhere between the carrots and the cookies, he spotted a bag that looked familiar. Directly in front of him was a copy of a FREITAG bag. Except this one was called «Donnerstag», and was mass-produced from flimsy new plastic.

Sure, they'd copied the bag, but not the idea behind a FREITAG bag. This bag was neither unique nor recycled, and it probably wasn't all that durable. It wasn't so much the day of the week (in German, Donnerstag is the day before Friday) that was so different, but the choice of material, the production method and the belief behind the product.

The supermarket's counterfeit caused a stir and was a big headache for our still pretty small bag-making operation, which at that time was working in a 60-sq.m studio in the Maag complex in Zurich's industrial district. «Can they do that?», «Is the Donnerstag bag the beginning of the end for FREITAG?». These questions caused sleepless nights for the Freitag brothers and their first permanent employee.

To everyone's relief, it didn't lead to a horrendous court battle or even the mass production of Donnerstag bags that would possibly have buried FREITAG. Thanks to a wave of sympathy from F-ans and friends, which was also taken up by the media, the retailer took the copy off its shelves and promised never again to name bags after days of the week.



■ INSPIRED BY BAG AND BELIEF

The culture of copying is omnipresent, not only in music, art or literature but also in design and fashion. And with our unique product and increasingly widespread recognition, we are inevitably attracting imitators. Some limit themselves to sewing the characteristic black-and-white FREITAG logo onto their own creations. And in some cases, imagination knows no bounds, even when it comes to naming: The list of copies like «FERTILE», «WOCHENENDE». or «FERIENTAG» is long.

Fortunately, some of the imitators take their inspiration both from the form and our beliefs and likewise focus on reusing materials or environment-friendly production processes.

■ AN HOMAGE TO THE COPY

As a tribute to this turning point in the then-still-young history of the company, the copy from back then will be reintroduced in a limited edition as the F13-D COPY CAT.

The Donnerstag label will be placed where the FREITAG logo is usually positioned. So, after almost 30 years, the copy will be an original in its own right. And we'll be donating 99% of the profits to to the social initiative of a Swiss retailer. And, of course, this time around, the bags are made of recycled truck tarps, as befits a FREITAG original.

PAUSE VIDEO 00:00:14 UNMUTE FULLSCREEN

■ THE DONNERSTAG WEEKS ARE OPEN

But that's not all: from September 19 to 30, with the invaluable support of designer Leandro Destefani, we'll be turning the store at Hardbrücke, the birthplace of the first FREITAG bag, into a supermarket.

Using objects salvaged from various secondhand platforms such as a vegetable display case, a perfectly functioning supermarket checkout with a conveyor belt, and a refrigerated shelf that won't be hooked up to power, we'll be transforming the FREITAG Flagship Store into an almost real supermarket for the Donnerstag-Wochen.

■ FURTHER ORIGINALS FROM TODAY AND TOMORROW

■ PRODUCT STORIES

THE CIRCULAR TARP

→ MORE ABOUT THE CIRCULAR TARP

■ THE CIRCULAR TRUCK TARP

Since 2020, together with other industrial partners, we've been developing a circular truck tarp which, even after a long second life as a FREITAG bag, won't end up in the garbage but back in the cycle. The first prototypes designed to close the technical material cycle are already out on their first test run.

■ THE CIRCULAR BACKPACK

In the summer of 2023, we embarked on a new cycle and sent the first circular backpack, made entirely without truck tarp, into production. Our latest circular development, Mono[PA6], consists exclusively of polyamide 6.

■ PRODUCT STORIES

THE MONO[PA6] BAGS

→ DISCOVER NOW

■ PRODUCT STORIES

THE CIRCULAR IPHONE CASES

→ MORE ABOUT THE CIRC-CASE SYSTEM

■ THE CIRCULAR CELLPHONE SLEEVE

We've given worn-out ski boots a next life as circular iPhone® protectors by the name of CIRC-CASE and combined the cellphone case with the customized F380 JUSTIN card holder made of truck tarp to create the super-individual CIRC-CASE system. In the process, we work together with various partners in Switzerland.

■ YOU MIGHT ALSO LIKE

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240.00 EUR

F11 LASSIE
240.00 EUR

F11 LASSIE
240.00 EUR

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■ NEVER MISS A THING

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